

WE THE USERS

The Second Zero

Where the road leads — the same internet, owned by its citizens, and how the money works

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Twice now, a cost that quietly governed everything has fallen toward nothing. The first time, we did not understand what was happening until the new owners had already moved in. The second time is happening now, while we are awake — and this essay is about what it makes possible, what it does not, and where it leads if we choose.

The first zero

For nearly all of human history, the expensive thing was *sharing*. An idea could be had for free, but moving it — copying it, carrying it, putting it in front of another mind — cost a monk's year, a printer's press, a broadcaster's tower. Whoever owned the means of sharing owned much of what got shared.

Then the internet drove the cost of sharing to zero. Any thought, any song, any picture could reach anyone on earth for nothing. We called it freedom, and for the word itself, it was.

But watch what happened to the *places*. The feed, the index, the marketplace, the inbox — the presses of the new age — were built by a handful of companies, owned by a handful of companies, and everything we said and made and did inside them became their raw material.¹ The first zero freed the sharing of things while quietly cornering the ownership of the places where sharing happens. It cost nothing to speak, and the value of a billion people speaking flowed to the few who owned the rooms.

That was the first zero's lesson, learned late: when a great cost collapses, the question that matters is not *what becomes free*. It is *who owns what gets built on the freedom*.

The second zero

Now a second cost is collapsing: the cost of *building* itself.

Software that once took a company and a year now takes a small team and a season; increasingly it takes one person and a conversation. The machines can write code, test it, refactor it, document it — not perfectly, but relentlessly, and cheaper every quarter. The craft is not disappearing; the *scarcity* of it is. Building an internet platform is on its way to costing roughly what it costs to describe one clearly.

Be honest about the default, because the default is not on our side. Cheap building reaches the incumbents first. They hold the models, the compute, the data, and the billion-user front door; a tide that lowers the cost of construction lifts the biggest builders most. Left alone, the second zero

concentrates — it deals the fastest hand to the players already holding the best cards. Nothing about this technology chooses us.

What the second zero does is narrower, and more important: for the first time since the internet began, it makes the platforms themselves *rebuildable*. The feed, the search, the market, the messenger — these were never miracles. They are software plus data plus trust. The software is becoming cheap. The data is ours by right — it could not exist without us.¹ The trust is the one thing that cannot be bought, only kept.

The first zero made it free to share what we make. The second makes it possible to own where we make it. Possible — not automatic. Ownership is not what the second zero does; it is what the second zero *permits*. It has to be chosen, and built, against the grain of what the technology would otherwise do.

The same rooms, a different deed

So picture the destination plainly, because a movement that cannot describe where it is going should not ask anyone to walk.

It looks, at first, unremarkable: the same kinds of rooms. A feed where your friends are. A search box that answers. A marketplace, a mailbox, a map. Built to the same standard of polish, because the tools that build them are the same tools the incumbents use. The difference is not on the screen. It is on the deed.

Each room is run by a community that sets the rules of its own house. The communities share a thin commonwealth — deliberately the weakest tier — holding only what must be common: identity, the Covenant, the Code.² Nothing is run in secret; the software that enforces the rules is public, and if the center ever betrays the people, the people can take the protocol and leave. That architecture is argued elsewhere in these essays. What has been missing, until now, is the plain answer to the plainest question: *where does the money go?*

Start with scope, honestly. This argument is strongest where the product is mostly information — social, search, media, messaging, coordination — and weakest where it is mostly atoms. Rebuilding the feed is software; rebuilding the warehouse network is not. The commonwealth begins where code and data are the whole game — which happens to be exactly where the shadows are harvested most.

How the money works

A user-owned internet will still earn money. Rooms cost something to run; services will be worth paying for; value will flow through the new network as surely as it flows through the old one. The question every co-op, commune, and republic has had to answer is the one we answer here: who gets what?

The answer has two parts, and the physical world already taught us both.

First, the revenue funds the government. Every functioning society takes part of what it produces and pays for the common work: the roads, the courts, the clerks, the people who keep the water clean. The commonwealth is no different. Out of what the network earns, it funds the people who do its necessary work — the builders who write and maintain the Code, the moderators who keep the rooms livable, the keepers of identity and security and the unglamorous machinery underneath. They are the civil service of the new internet, and they are paid — paid well, and paid

openly, on a budget everyone can read — because a commons that expects its hardest work for free will watch that work quietly stop.³ These are wages. They are earned, they differ with the work, and they end when the work ends.

Second, the profit is divided equally — one person, one share. After the common work is funded, what remains belongs to the citizens, all of them, identically. Not weighted by usage, not multiplied for founders, not tiered by talent. The founder's dividend and the newcomer's dividend are the same number.

Understand exactly what is and is not being claimed. This is not the claim that everyone contributes equally — no one believes that, and the wage line above exists precisely because work differs. It is a claim about *ownership*: the commonwealth's profit is the return on things no one made alone — the pooled shadows of every member, the network that is valuable only because everyone is in it, the trust that belongs to the whole body or to no one. Ownership of the commons follows personhood, not output. Wages are for work. The dividend is for citizenship.

This is not a utopian invention. Alaska has run the shape of it for two generations: oil revenue funds the state's work, and every resident — every one, identically — receives the same yearly dividend from what the commons earns.⁴ No Alaskan pretends every resident contributed equally to the oil. The dividend is not a wage and was never meant to be one. It is what it looks like when a people owns something together and refuses to pretend otherwise.

And notice what the flat share quietly abolishes: the position of *owner-above-the-rest*. In the old internet, the people who run the platform also own the overwhelming share of it, and that double role — referee and richest player — is the root of nearly everything these essays indict. Here the roles are severed. The people who run the commonwealth draw salaries the citizens can see. Nobody — not the first believer, not the best engineer, not the largest community — draws rent on the public square. Returns on work are earned. Returns on *position* do not exist.

One person, one share

Strict equality has a price, and honesty requires the sticker.

The flatter and more unconditional the dividend, the richer the prize for a counterfeit citizen. If every member receives an equal share, the most profitable thing a bad actor can do is *be many members* — and eight billion equal shares are worth faking. Every scheme of common ownership eventually meets this problem; a digital one meets it on day one, at machine speed.

So the entire economy rests on a single gate: **membership grounded in real, verifiable personhood**. One human being, one membership, one share — verified strongly enough that manufacturing citizens is harder than the dividend is worth. This is a founding requirement of the constitution, not an implementation detail, and it is genuinely hard: proving unique personhood at global scale, without building the very surveillance apparatus this movement exists to end, is one of the open problems of the age. We do not pretend it is solved. We state it as the condition: the commonwealth's economics are only as sound as its answer to *who counts as one person* — which is why the Covenant must treat personhood the way constitutions treat citizenship: as the first question, answered in the open, amended in the open, and never delegated to a private party with something to sell.

If that gate cannot be built, the flat dividend cannot honestly be paid, and it would be better to say so plainly than to pay a dividend to whoever owns the most machines. We believe it can be built. It is the kind of problem the second zero was made for.

Leaving

No one will be marched into this. There is no expropriation in the plan, no law compelling anyone off the old platforms — the entire moral claim of the movement depends on the exit being chosen. That is also, frankly, the hard part. Network effects are why people stay in rooms they hate: everyone they know is already there, and a better room is worth little empty.

Which is why the way out is not individual but *communal*. A person alone cannot leave the feed; their people can. A congregation, a guild, a fandom, a town — a community that already knows where its members are can move together and arrive together, and its room is full on day one. This is why the call asks, before anything else, *where would you gather?* The map of communities willing to move is the map of the exit.

The first zero was used on us before we understood it. The second is arriving while we are awake, and this time the question is on the table before the rooms are built: who will own them?

No one chose the first internet. It was built — and now building is nearly free. The first zero freed the word. The second frees the work. Whether it frees *us* is not a law of nature. It is a draft, and the pen is on the table.



SOURCES & NOTES

1. What the shadow is made of, and why it belongs to the person who casts it, is the subject of *Your Digital Shadow*. ↔↔
2. The three tiers — and why the commonwealth is deliberately the weakest of them — are argued in *Ambition Against Ambition*. ↔
3. The economics of sustaining common work, and what happens to commons that refuse to pay for it, are taken up in *The Longer Race*. ↔
4. The Alaska Permanent Fund, established 1976, invests a share of the state's oil revenue; since 1982 it has paid every eligible Alaska resident an identical annual dividend from the fund's earnings. ↔